

BEST

Management Advice

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“LEADERSHIP SHOULD BE ASSESSED AT THE INDIVIDUAL LEVEL”

Q Despite progress in diversity and female leadership in Indian companies, where do women leadership programmes fall short?

Most programmes remain event-driven rather than systemic. They tend to emphasise training and networking but often fail to address deeper structural barriers like bias in succession planning, absence of strong sponsorship, and rigid organisational cultures. Without embedding accountability into leadership pipelines and organisational strategy, these initiatives risk becoming symbolic gestures rather than catalysts for meaningful transformation.

Q Have you found any significant differences on this front between Indian family businesses, MNCs and start-ups?

Family businesses in India have, in some cases, made notable progress, with certain families actively encouraging participation of daughters—and even daughters-in-law—in



business operations. Multinationals typically bring structured diversity frameworks driven by global mandates; however, execution in India sometimes fail to account for cultural nuances. Start-ups, often progressive in mindset, tend to underperform in practice.

Q In a number of studies in India and overseas, women managers have clearly outshone men in their leadership competencies. Could you elaborate?

Inequity is exacerbated by opaque compensation practices. Solutions include pay audits, linking leadership KPIs to diversity outcomes

I am not an advocate of gender-based stereotyping. I have seen male leaders excel in qualities often attributed to

women—such as compassion, or collaboration—just as I have seen women demonstrate traits traditionally associated with men, including decisiveness and risk-taking. In today’s world, leadership should be assessed at the individual level, with each person evaluated on their unique strengths and attributes, irrespective of gender.

Q Why does gender wealth/salary gaps exist in companies? What can be done to bring parity?

Inequity is exacerbated by opaque compensation practices. Solutions include rigorous pay audits, linking leadership KPIs (key performance indicators) to diversity outcomes, and creating intentional pathways for women into senior P&L responsibilities. Transparent communication around remuneration and promotion criteria is critical.

Q How significant is the issue of women harassment in India Inc?

Under reporting and uneven enforcement weaken effectiveness, while fear of retaliation and reputational damage deter reporting. **BT**